

rest of the kids at school, partly because he didn't share the other boys' interest in girls. Nick's daughter, then 8, hated school so much she refused to go. Every morning she fought, screaming and crying, as her parents pushed her toward the school-bus door. What to do?

Nick and his wife decided to take both kids out of school and travel around the world. The kids soaked up the sun in Bali, saw India's worst poverty, rode camels in Pakistan, and cried tears of joy when they finally reached Germany's clean sheets and McDonald's hamburgers.

When they returned to the Costa del Sol a year later, both kids went back to school where they had left off. They were a year older than the rest of the kids and had an easier time adjusting. They seemed more dispassionate, more ready to accept the bad with the good. The son started to take girls to parties on weekends. The daughter began to go to school without much fuss.

In chatting about very early retirement over the years, I've found that many people find the idea scary at first. It *is* hard to grasp. But when people without children hear the idea, they tend to react differently than parents. Those without children tend to focus on *why* very early retirement threatens them. They think through the implications of quitting work, selling the house, and moving to the South. They wonder if they have enough net worth. They imagine what life might be like if they didn't have to go to the office. I'm generalizing here. But whether the idea appeals to them or not, people without children tend to go to the *substance* of the idea of very early retirement.

A parent, on the other hand, tends to react to the idea by asking if I have kids. When I say no, I invariably see and hear a sigh of relief. "Ah," says the parent, with a knowing look around the room, eyes pleading for confirmation from other parents. "You don't have kids, Paul. It's impossible to retire with kids."